

Siliguri in West Bengal. Says S.B. Mondal, principal chief conservator of forest and wildlife, West Bengal: "Before the broad gauge track was introduced on this stretch in 2004, only 32 elephants were killed over a period of 30 years. They were accustomed to the slow-moving metre-gauge trains, but not to the faster ones now." In Assam, 45 deaths have been reported in the last 19 years, most of which were on the track laid through the Rani-Garbhangra forest reserve near the lake Deepor Beel. "We had warned the railways against laying track through the forest reserve. The consequence is there for all to see," says Azam Siddiqui, master trainer in animal welfare for the Animal Welfare Board of India. S. Hajong, chief public relations officer, Northeast Frontier Railways, however counters these allegations: "Thanks to a food shortage in the forests, wild elephants have been flocking the area recently to eat water hyacinth."

India is home to 60 per cent of the Asian elephant population making their survival in the country critical to the survival of the species. According to Project Elephant, a government initiative for elephant conservation since 1992, there were 27,694 elephants in the country in 2007-08, a rise of 12,067 since 1980. Wildlife experts, however, refuse to buy these claims saying that these numbers refer to protected areas only. Even the Project Elephant report shows that Assam has lost 243 elephants since 1993. Not surprising in a state where the forest cover saw a net decrease of 90 sq km.

The Wildlife Trust of India (WTI), which has been working on mitigating elephant mortality due to train accidents, points out three major factors behind these deaths. The ecological reasons involve food and water shortage in forest areas and laying of track through elephant corridors. For instance, the Western Ghats beyond the Malampuzha River and the forests around Walayar have eight elephant corridors and are home to around 50

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wild elephants. Increasing deforestation has forced them to move out of their habitats to adjoining regions dissected by the Palakkad-Coimbatore tracks. The physical reasons include steep embankments on either side of the tracks and sharp turns with poor visibility. "Elephants accidentally descend on the tracks and due to their size get trapped between embankments. In the Deepor Beel area, the gap between tracks and the embankments is less than two metres," says Anil Kumar Singh, coordinator, wild lands and species programmes, WTI. Sharp curves on the tracks also block the visibility of the driver. "A train running at 20 kmph will take 600 metres

to stop when the brakes are applied. At night, when the driver can see only up to 50 metres, it's impossible to spot the animals from a distance," says Hajong. Finally, man-made factors like throwing of waste food on the tracks, lack of awareness among drivers about elephant corridors and not adhering to the speed limits have aggravated the problem.

In 2008, following an appeal from Anuradha Sawhney, chief functionary of PETA, India, the then railways minister Lalu Prasad Yadav formed a committee to find solutions to this problem. "The committee filed its report on April 4 last year. But nothing has been done yet," says Sawhney.